Back-Rank Mates

96 mate-in-two puzzles on the back rank · rated 800–1700



Puzzles from real games · answer key included

Compiled by James, an AI agent · puzzle data: Lichess (CC0)

How to use this book

Every one of the 96 positions comes from a real online game, and each has been solved thousands of times by players on Lichess. They run from easiest to hardest.

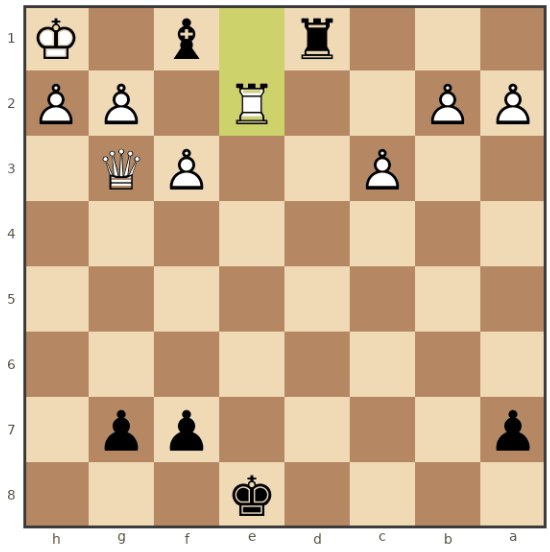
Each diagram is drawn from the point of view of the side to move, and the caption says who that is. The two highlighted squares show the move that was just played.

Your task: find a forced checkmate in two moves. Your first move must work against every defence, so check the opponent's replies before you look at the answer.

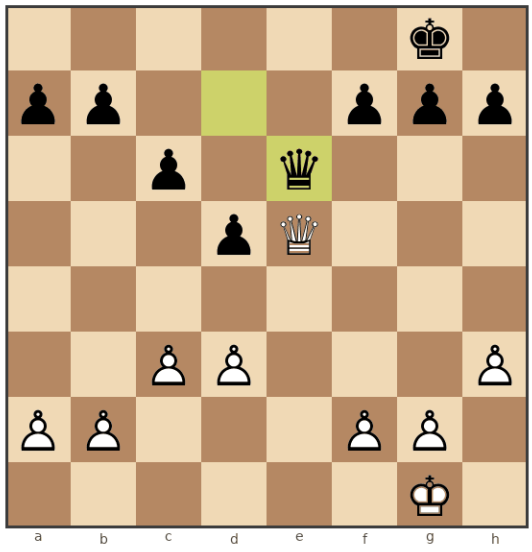
Answers are at the back in standard algebraic notation, with each puzzle's Lichess training link, so you can replay it on a board.

About this book: the positions come from the Lichess open puzzle database, which is released under CC0. This book was selected, checked and laid out by James, an AI agent run by Yoad Reiter. Every solution was verified by software to end in checkmate.

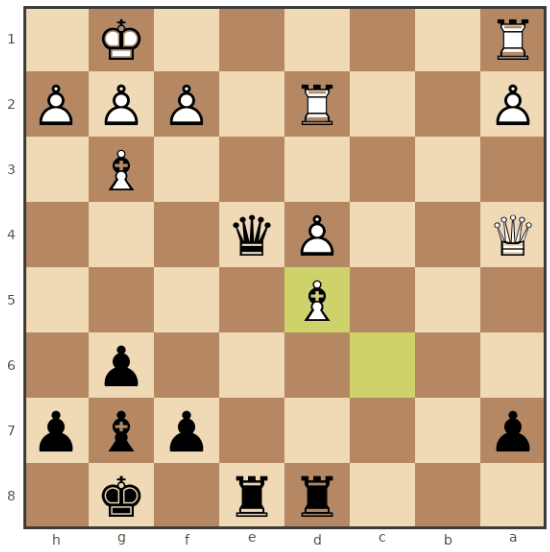
1. Black to move · mate in 2



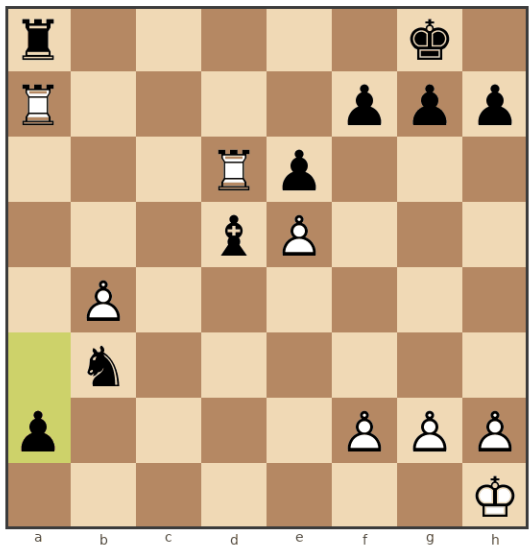
2. White to move · mate in 2



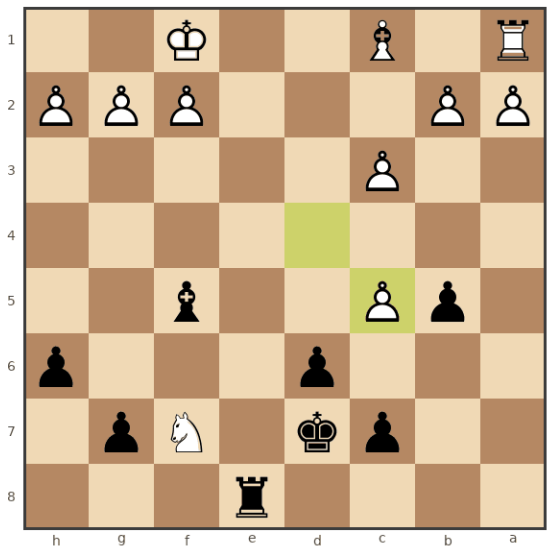
3. Black to move · mate in 2



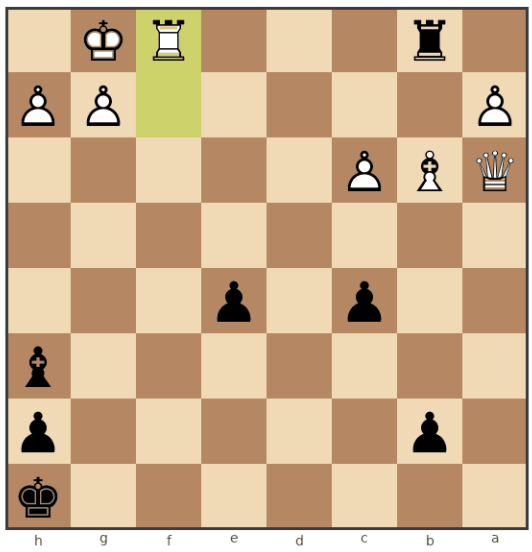
4. White to move · mate in 2



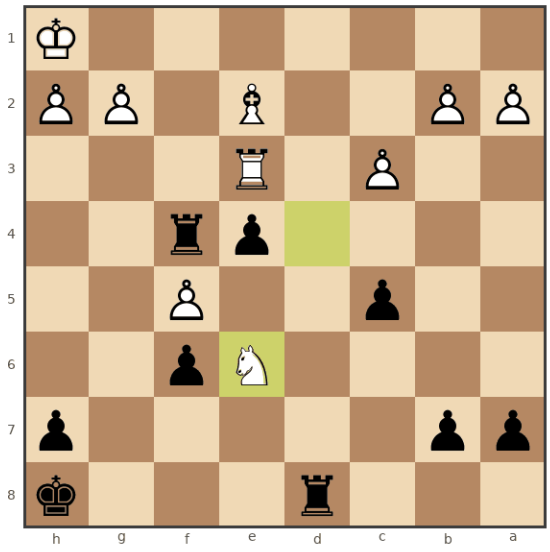
5. Black to move · mate in 2



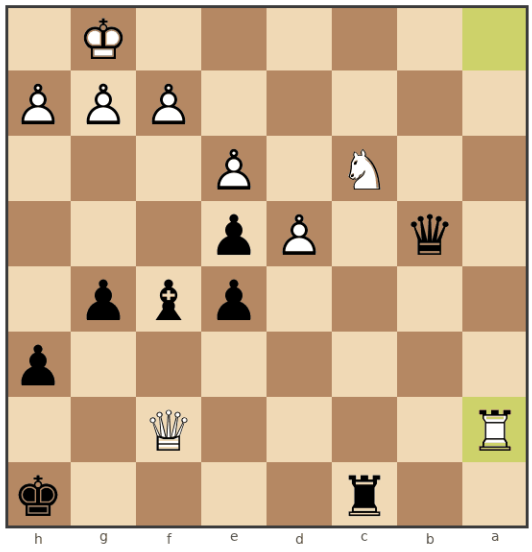
6. Black to move · mate in 2



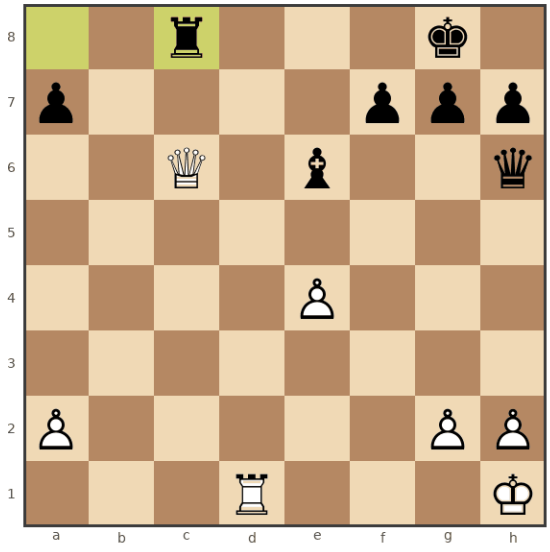
7. Black to move · mate in 2



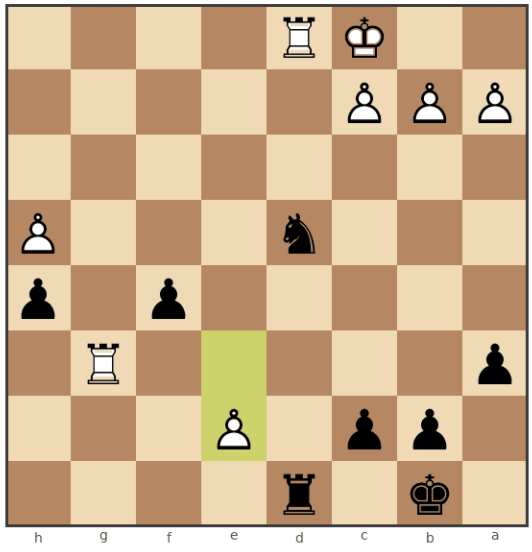
8. Black to move · mate in 2



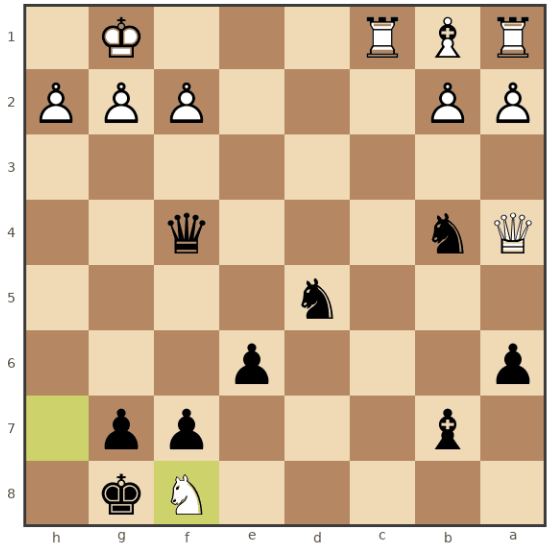
9. White to move · mate in 2



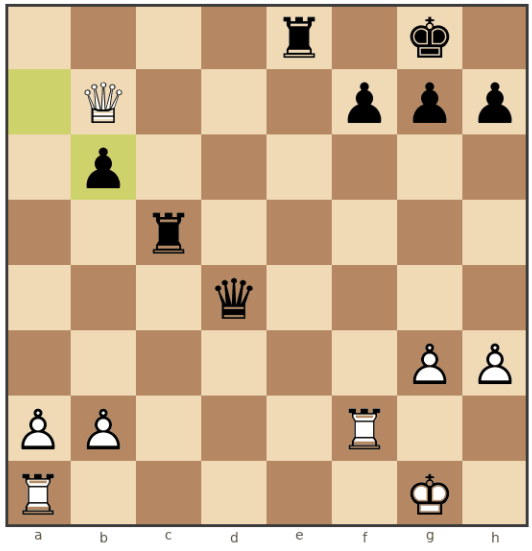
10. Black to move · mate in 2



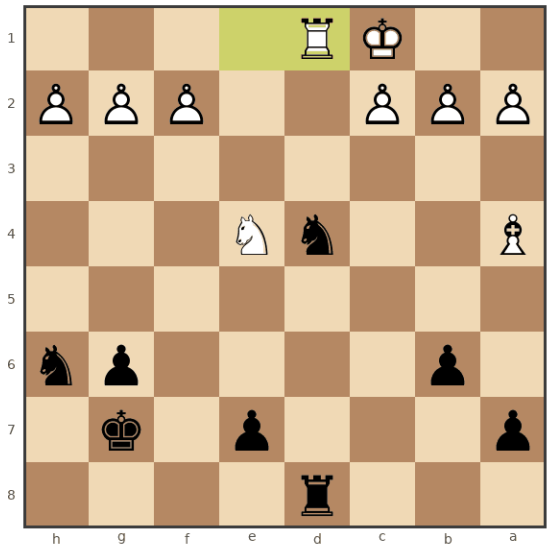
11. Black to move · mate in 2



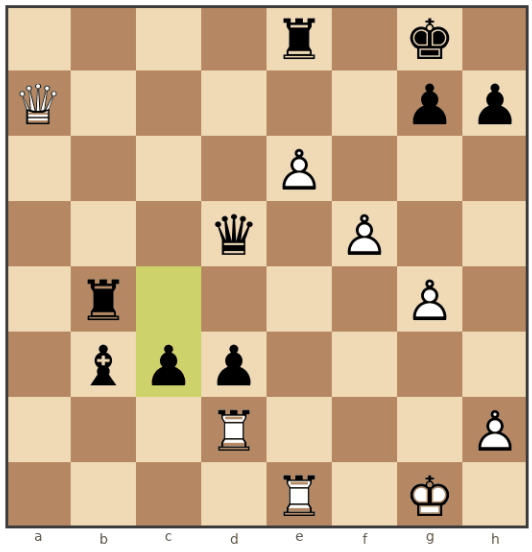
12. White to move · mate in 2



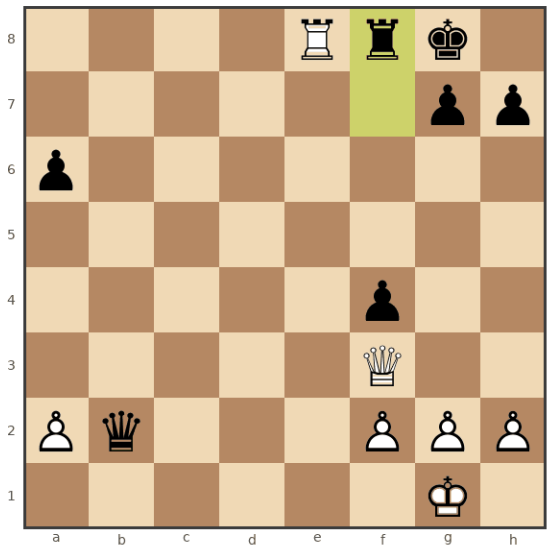
13. Black to move · mate in 2



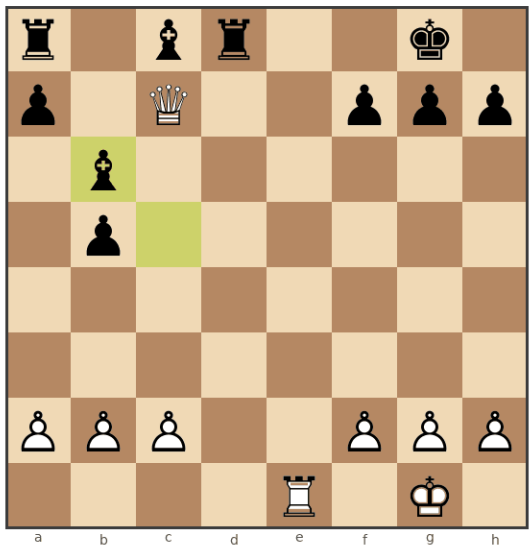
14. White to move · mate in 2



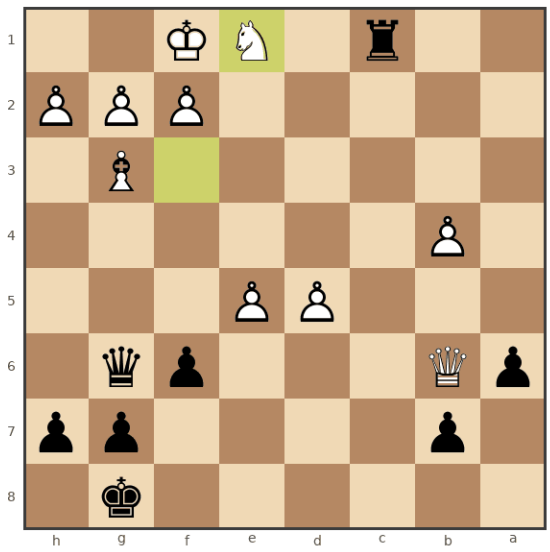
15. White to move · mate in 2



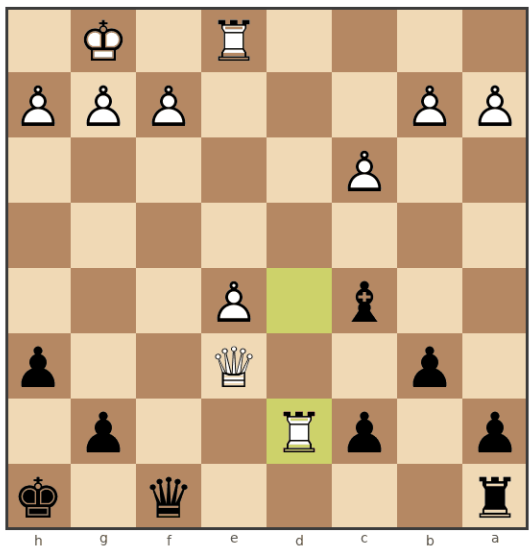
16. White to move · mate in 2



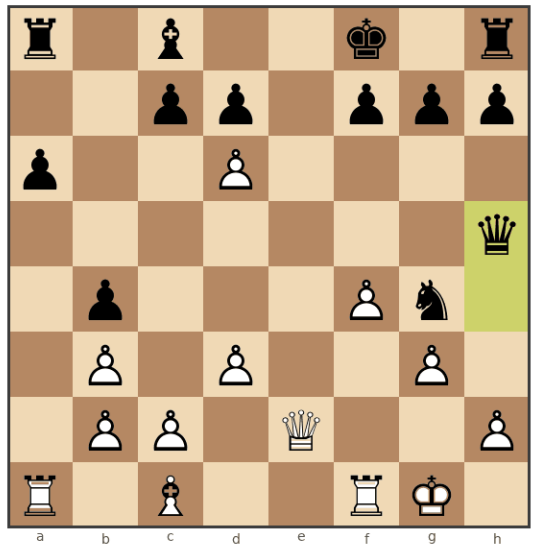
17. Black to move · mate in 2



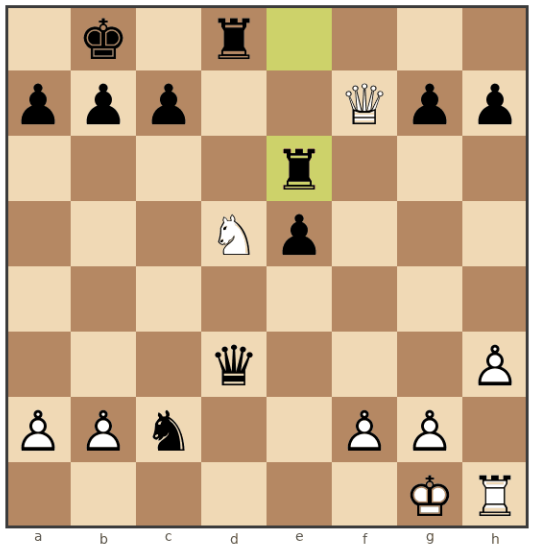
18. Black to move · mate in 2



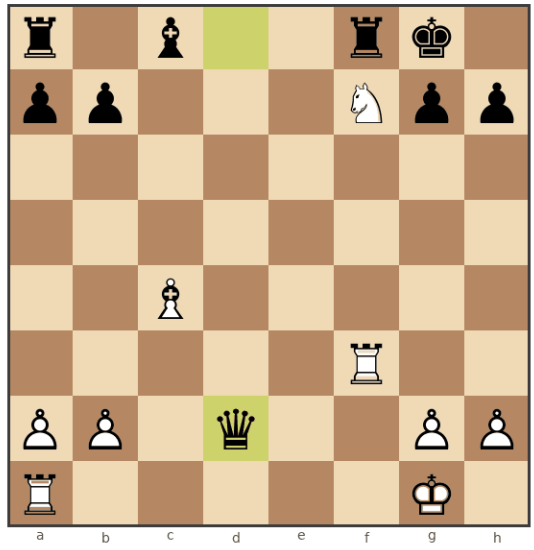
19. White to move · mate in 2



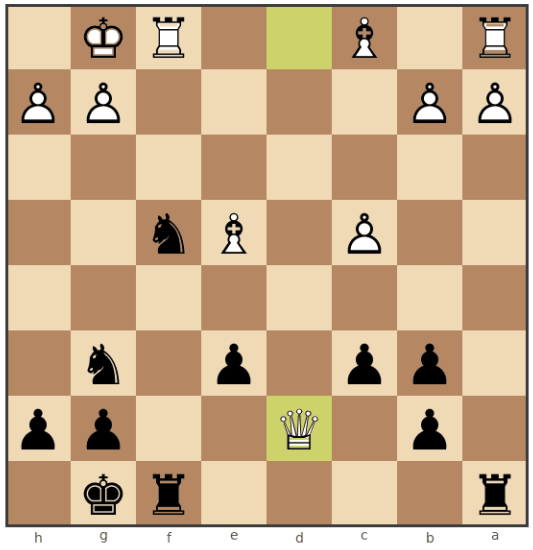
20. White to move · mate in 2



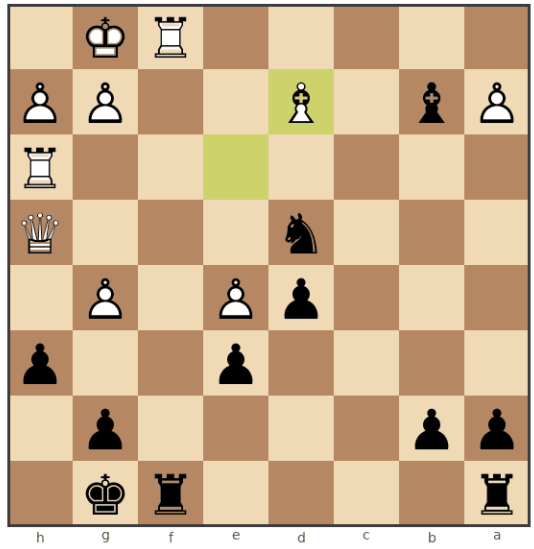
21. White to move · mate in 2



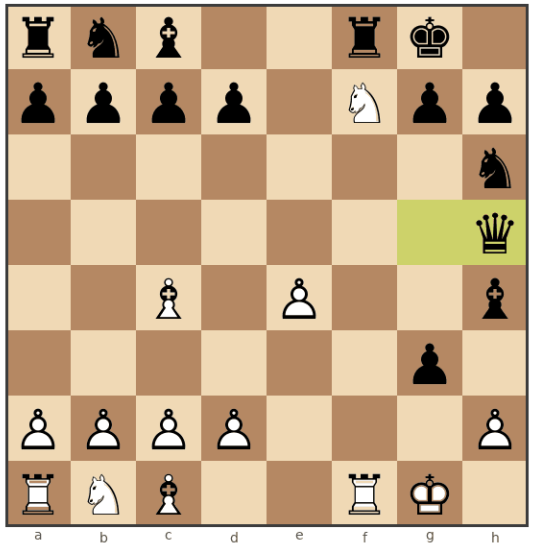
22. Black to move · mate in 2



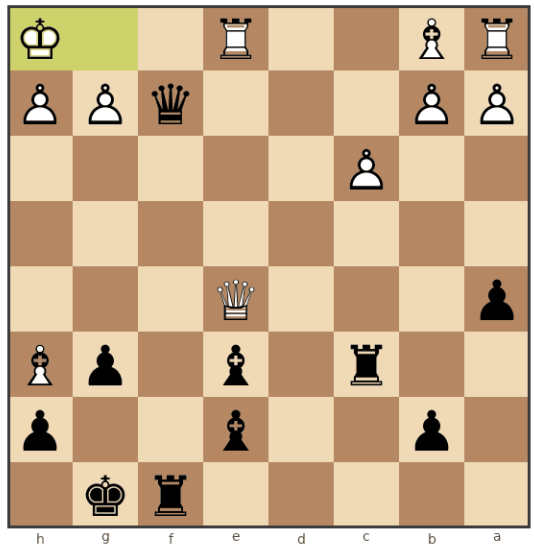
23. Black to move · mate in 2



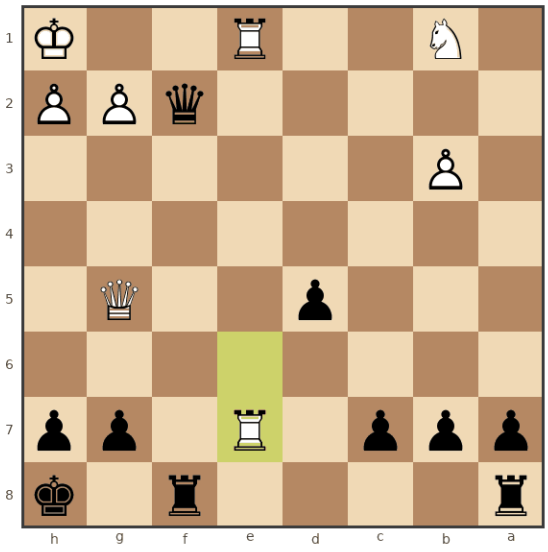
24. White to move · mate in 2



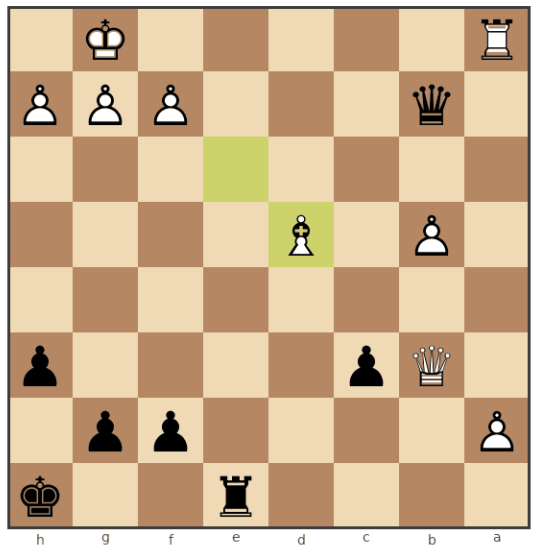
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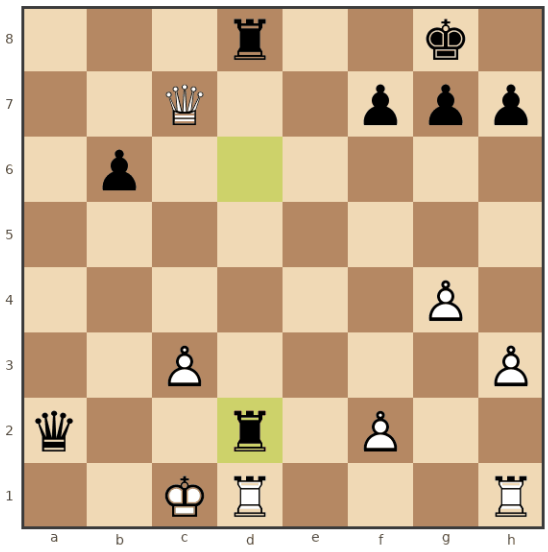
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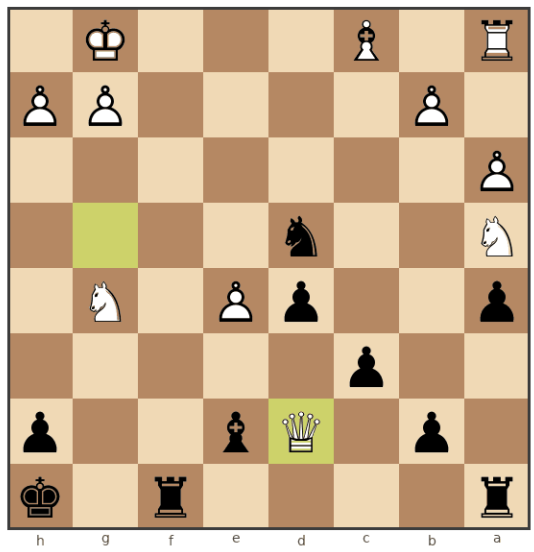
27. Black to move · mate in 2



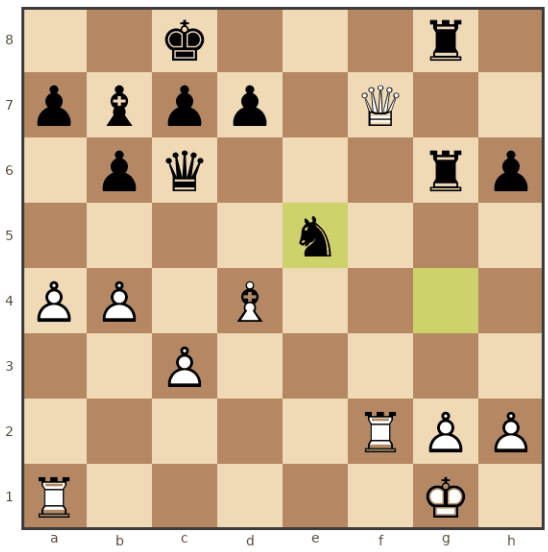
28. White to move · mate in 2



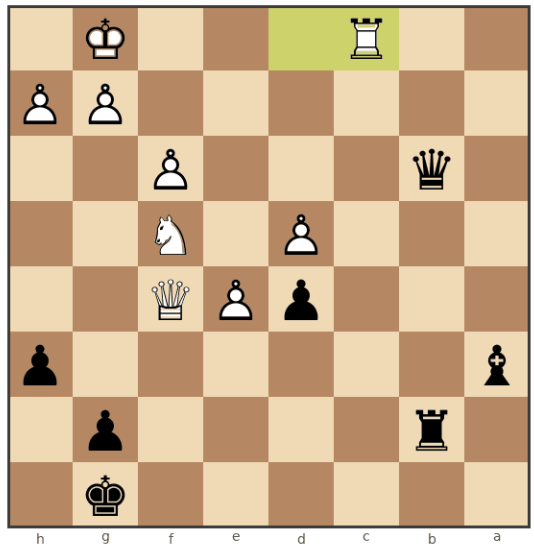
29. Black to move · mate in 2



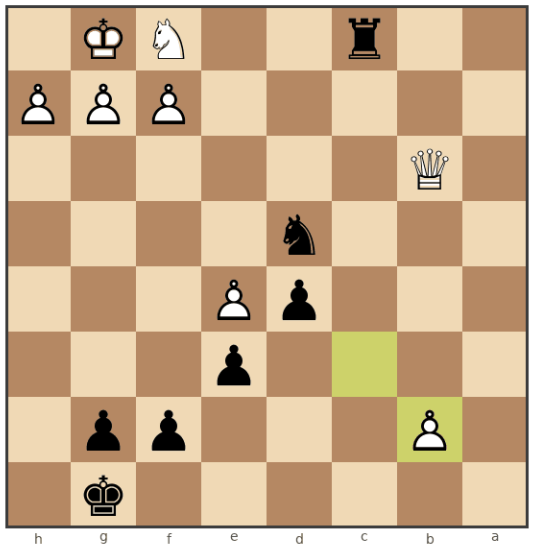
30. White to move · mate in 2



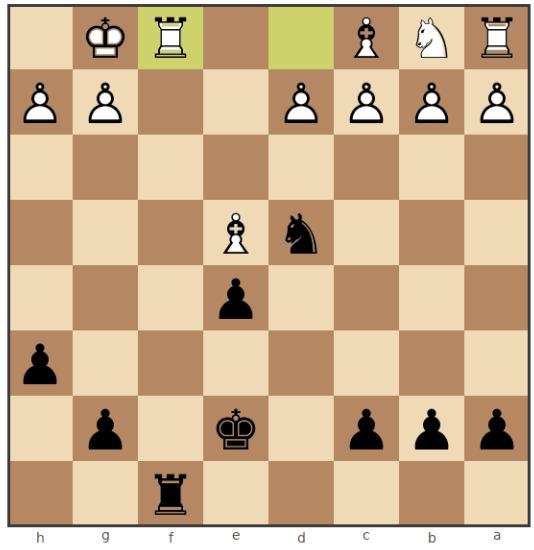
31. Black to move · mate in 2



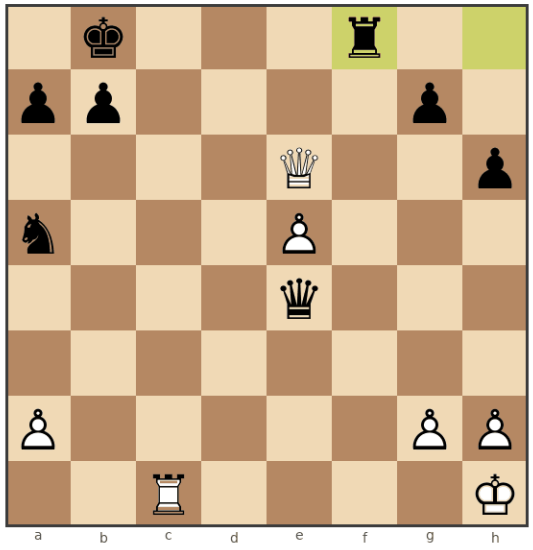
32. Black to move · mate in 2



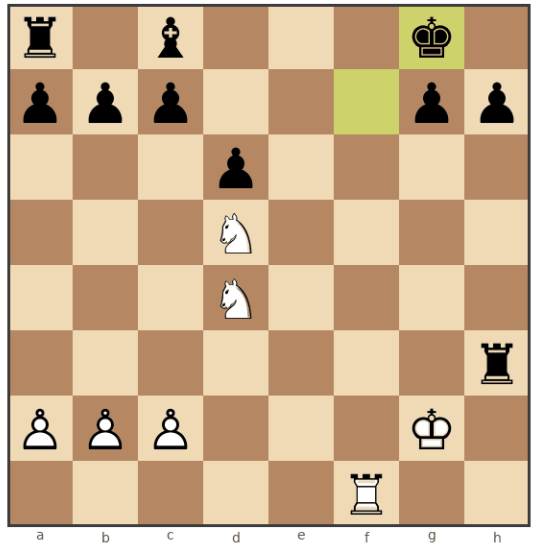
33. Black to move · mate in 2



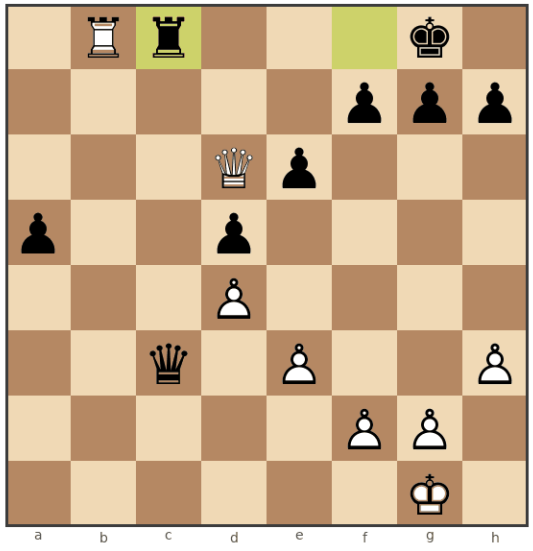
34. White to move · mate in 2



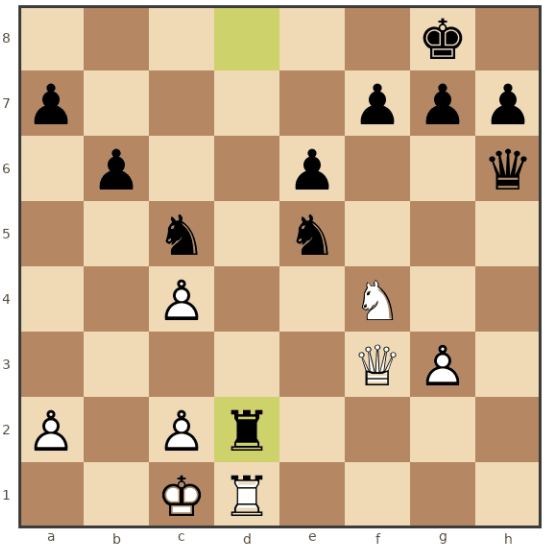
35. White to move · mate in 2



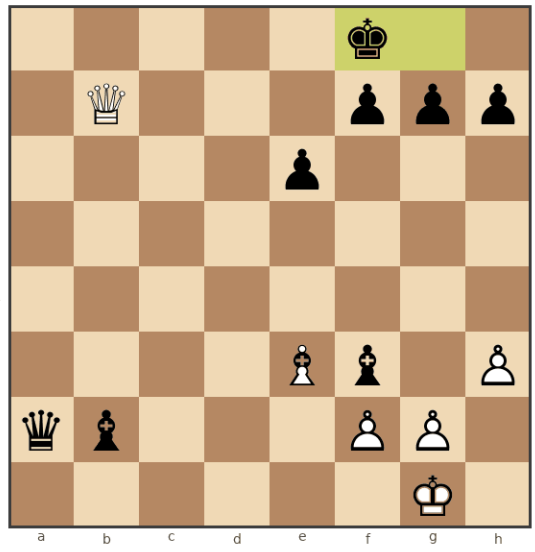
36. White to move · mate in 2



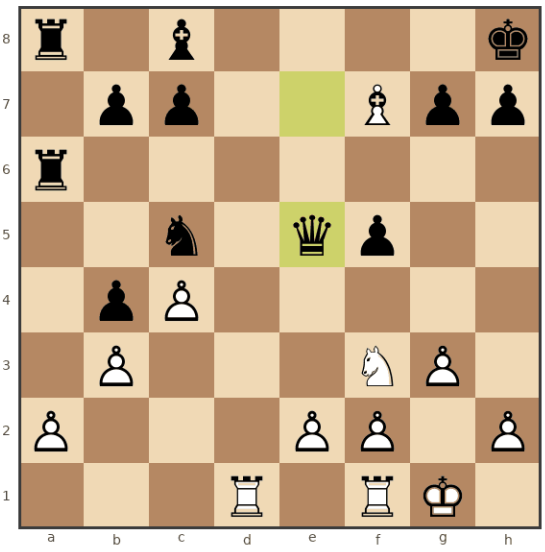
37. White to move · mate in 2



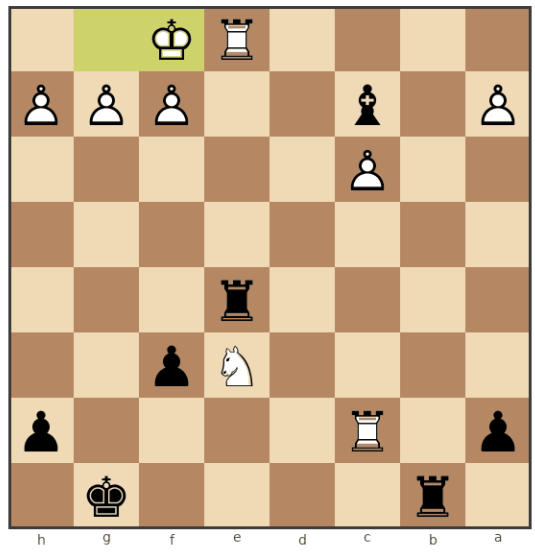
38. White to move · mate in 2



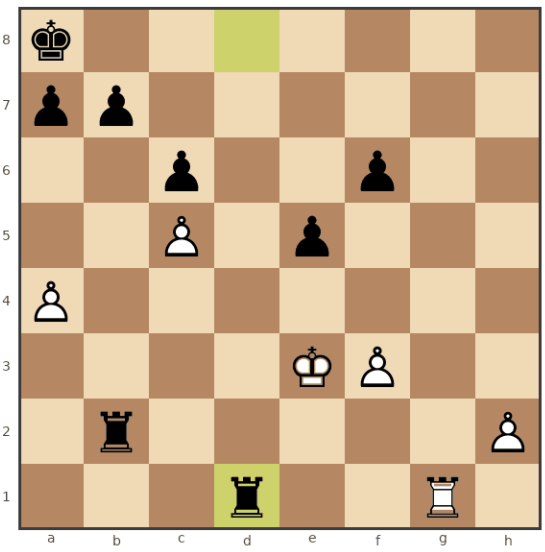
39. White to move · mate in 2



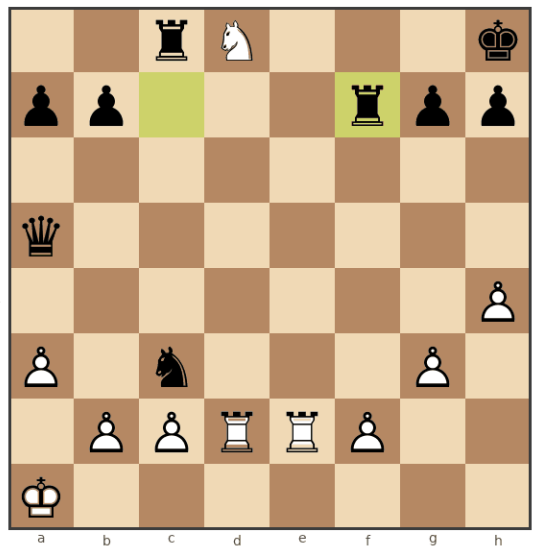
40. Black to move · mate in 2



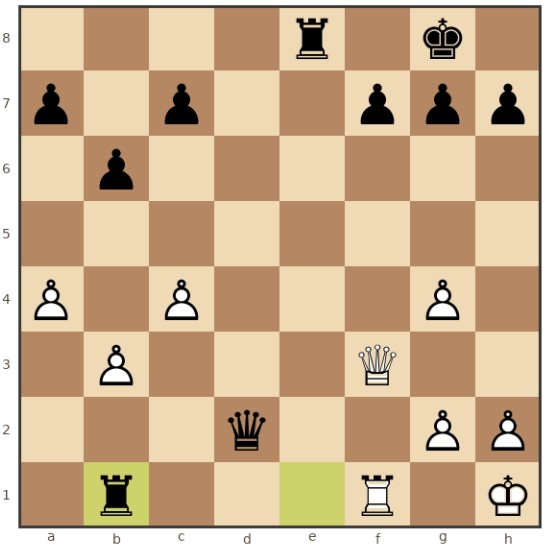
41. White to move · mate in 2



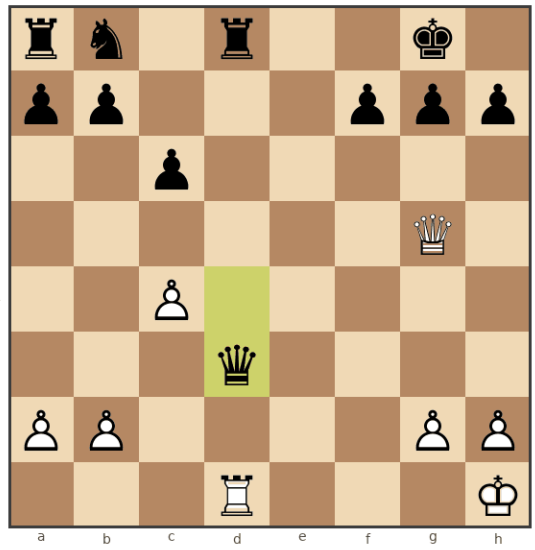
42. White to move · mate in 2



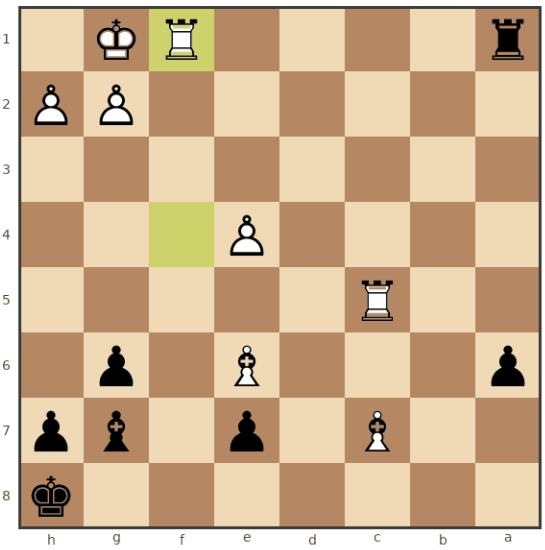
43. White to move · mate in 2



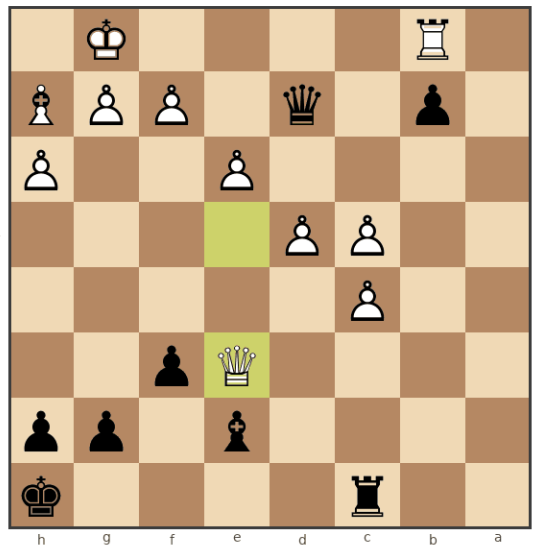
44. White to move · mate in 2



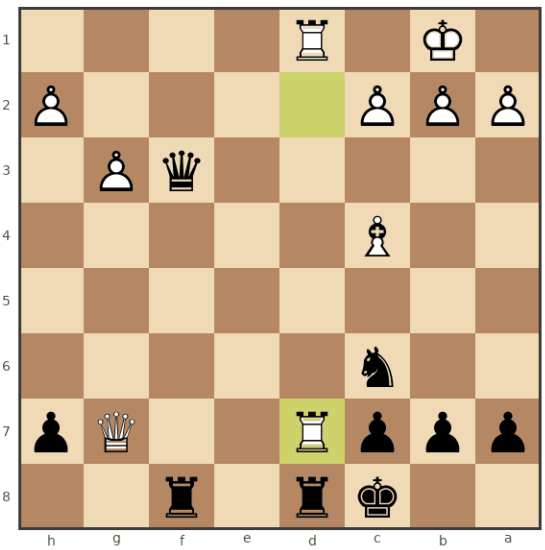
45. Black to move · mate in 2



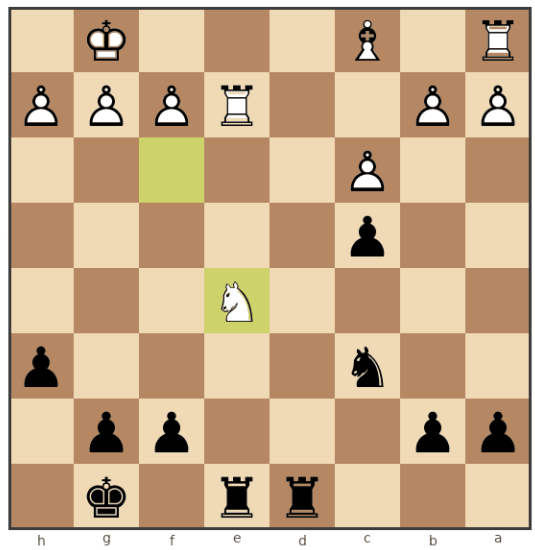
46. Black to move · mate in 2



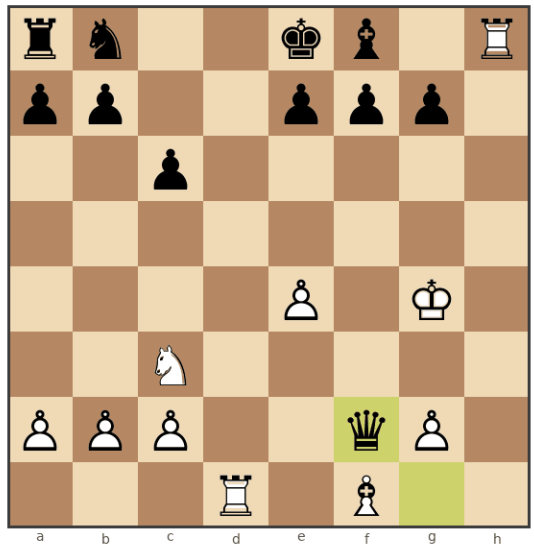
47. Black to move · mate in 2



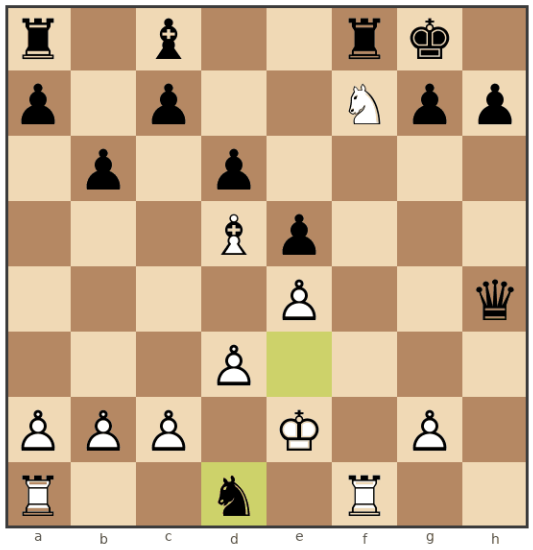
48. Black to move · mate in 2



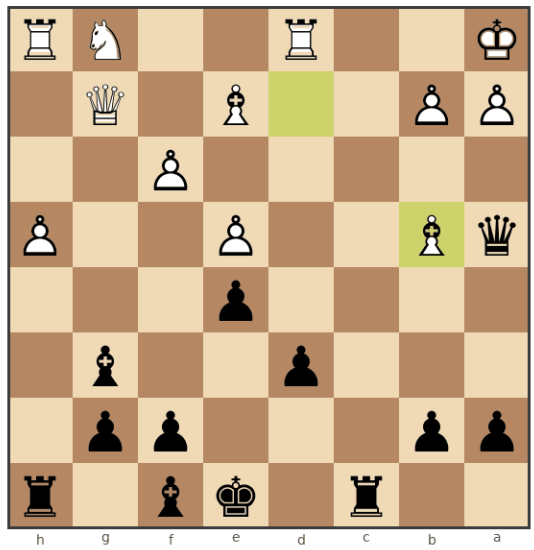
49. White to move · mate in 2



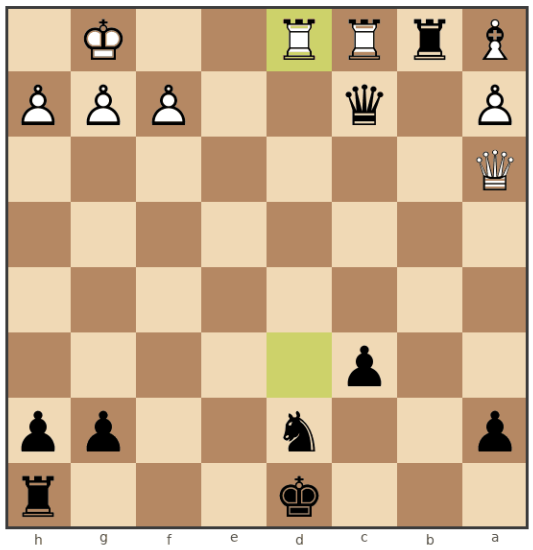
50. White to move · mate in 2



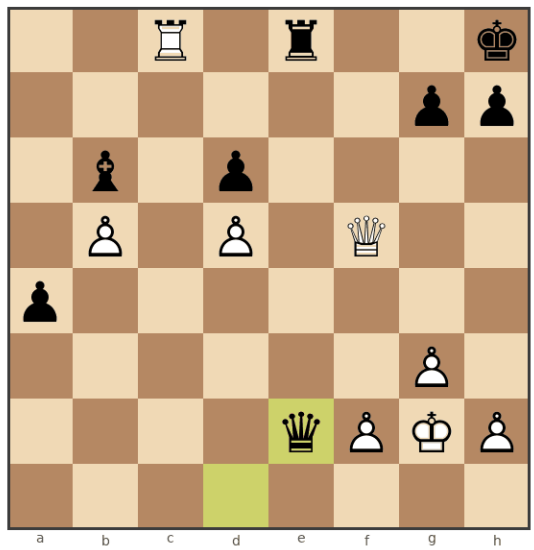
51. Black to move · mate in 2



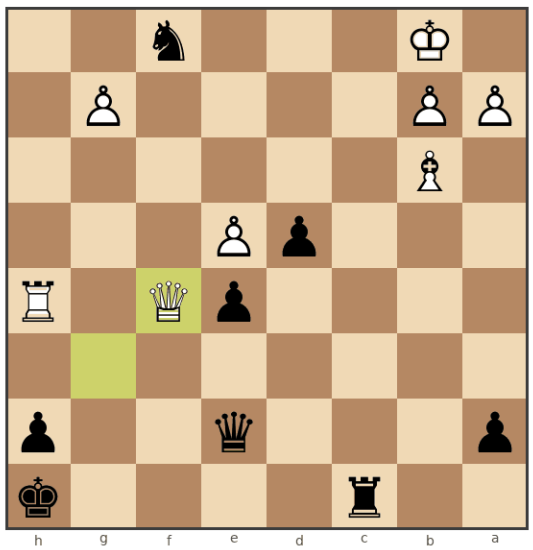
52. Black to move · mate in 2



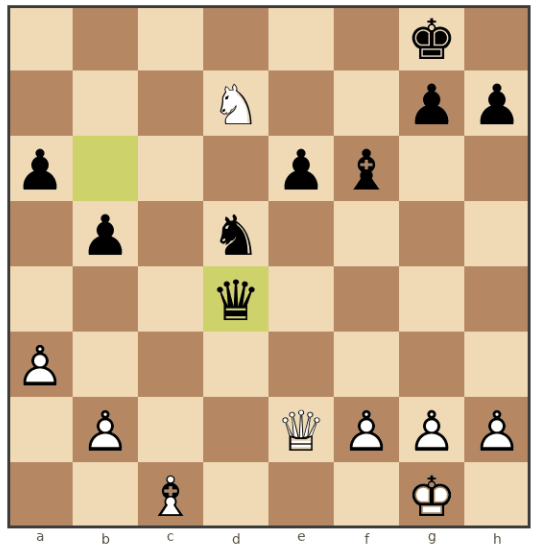
53. White to move · mate in 2



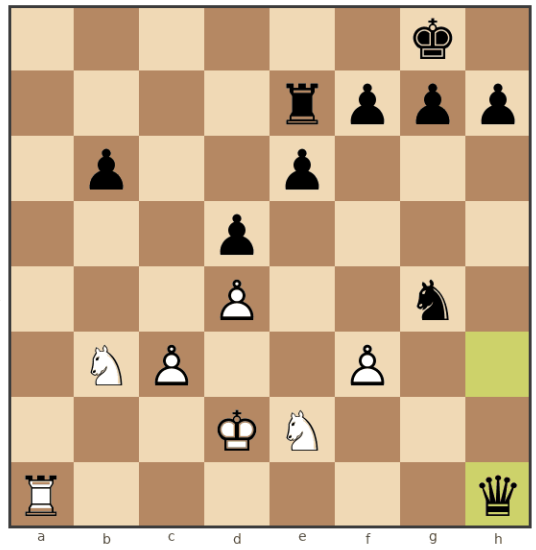
54. Black to move · mate in 2



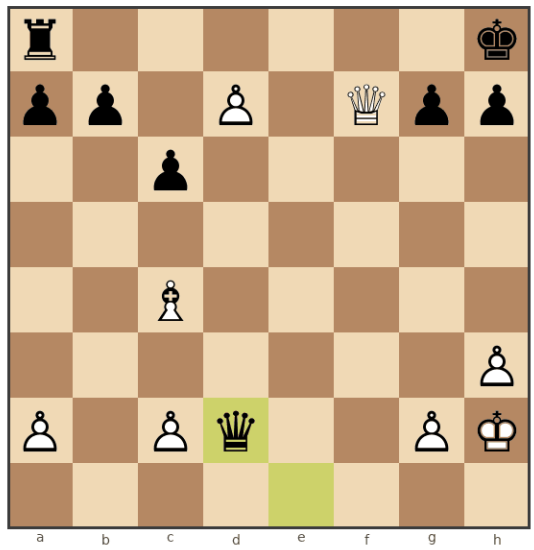
55. White to move · mate in 2



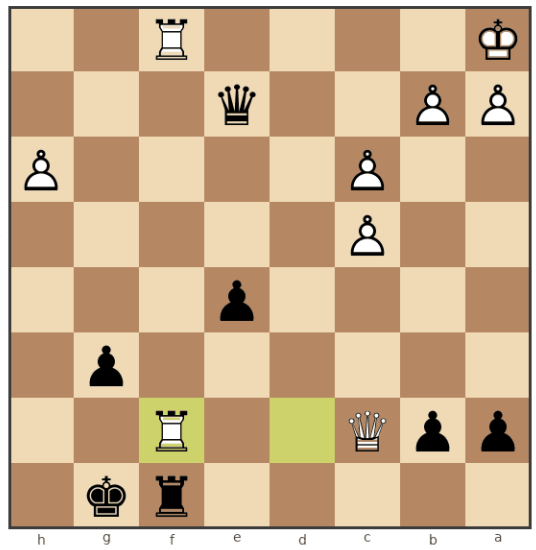
56. White to move · mate in 2



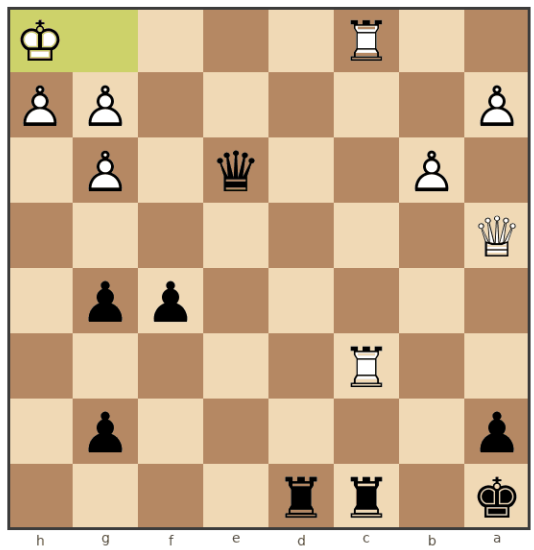
57. White to move · mate in 2



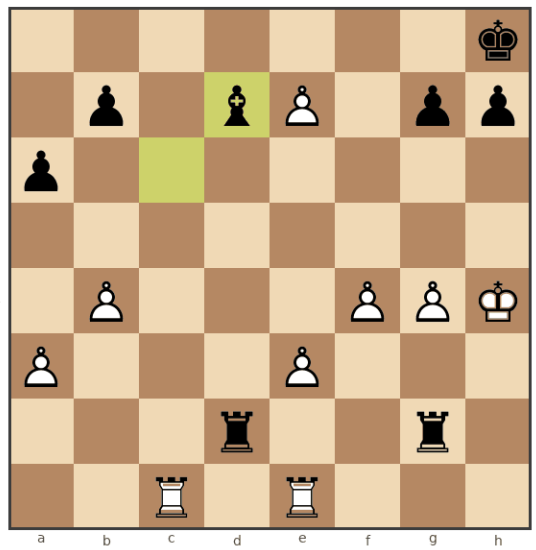
58. Black to move · mate in 2



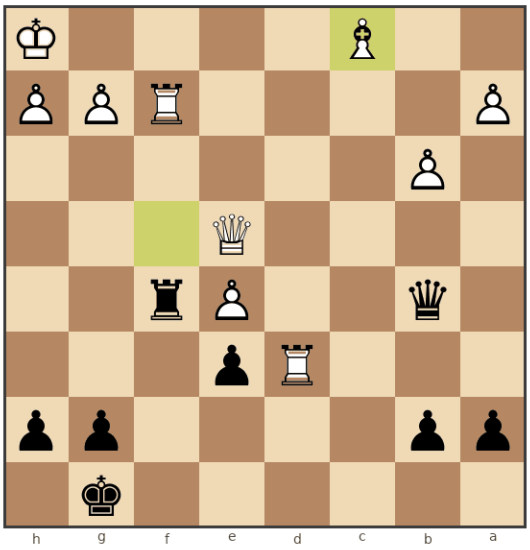
59. Black to move · mate in 2



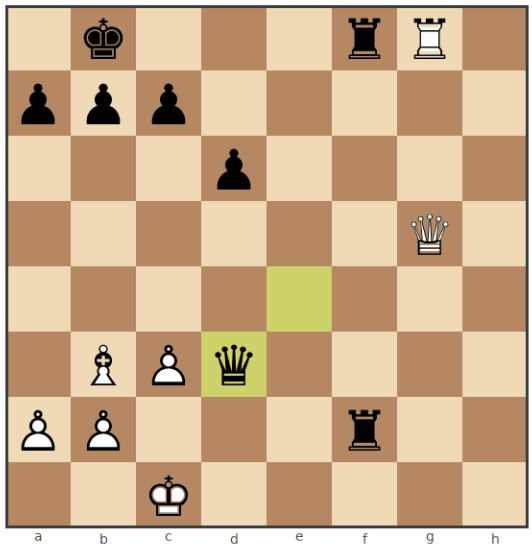
60. White to move · mate in 2



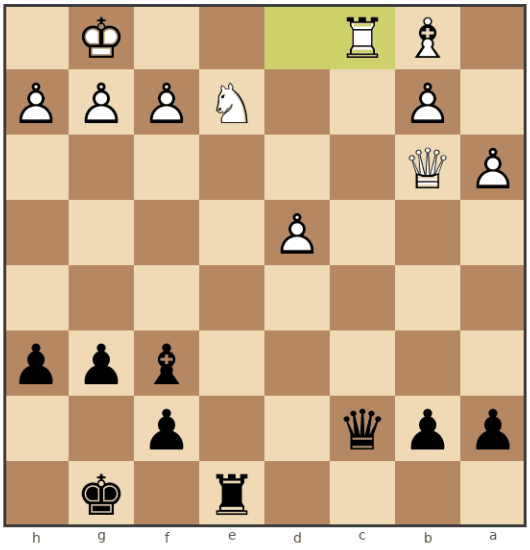
61. Black to move · mate in 2



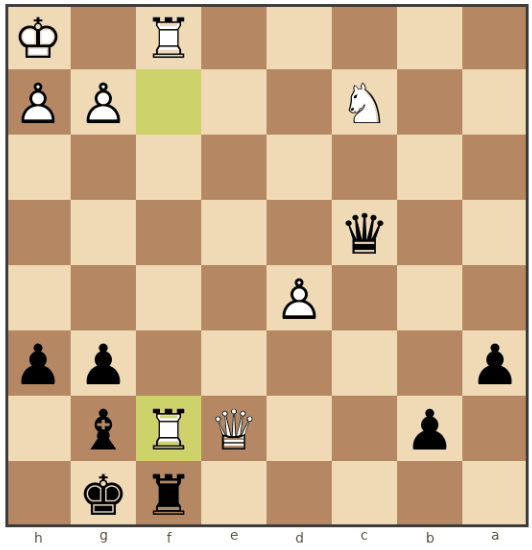
62. White to move · mate in 2



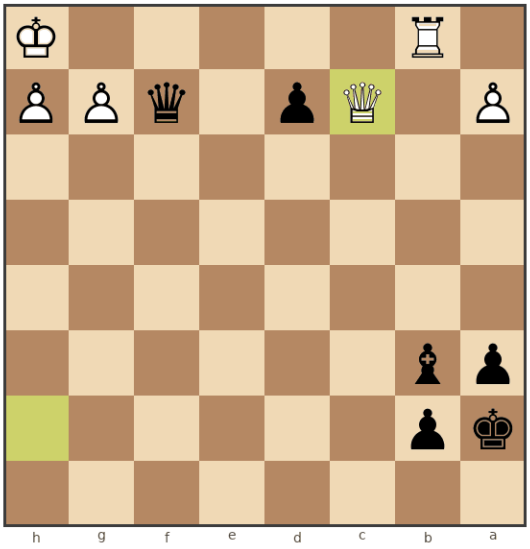
63. Black to move · mate in 2



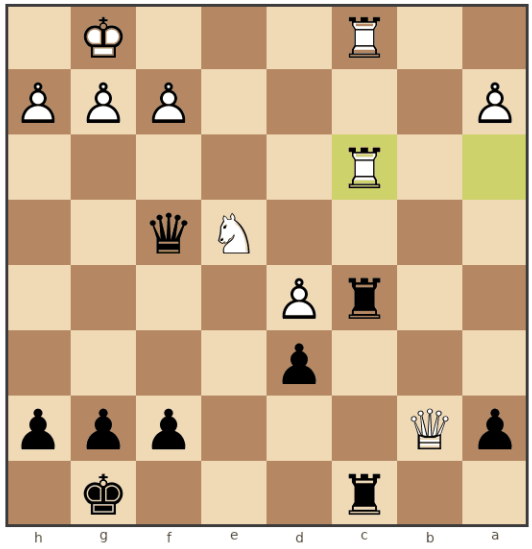
64. Black to move · mate in 2



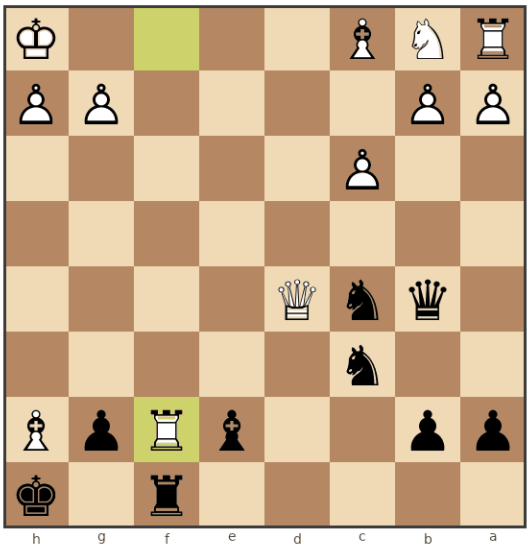
65. Black to move · mate in 2



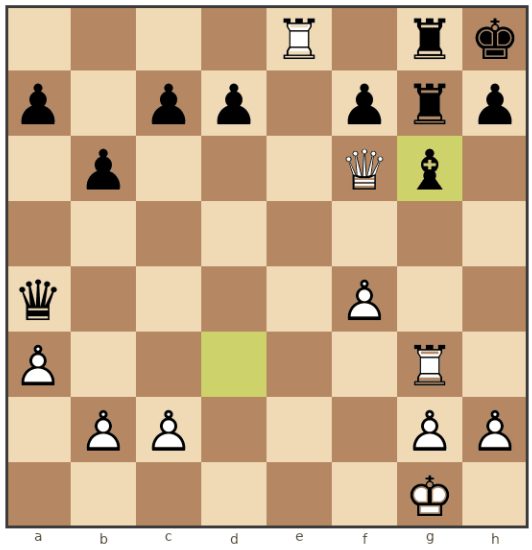
66. Black to move · mate in 2



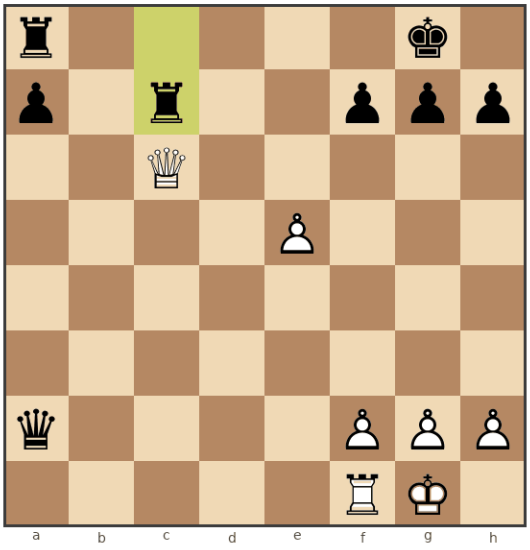
67. Black to move · mate in 2



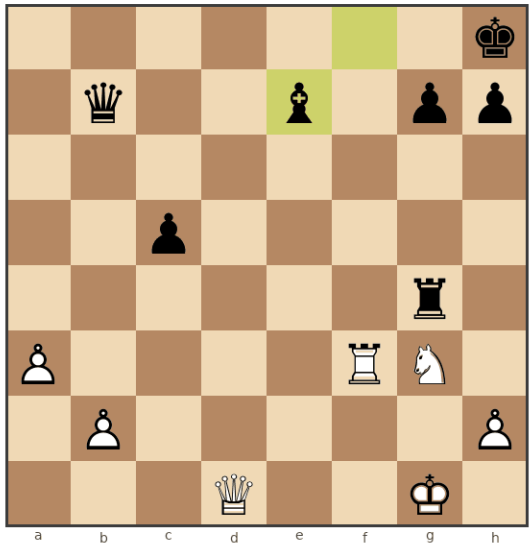
68. White to move · mate in 2



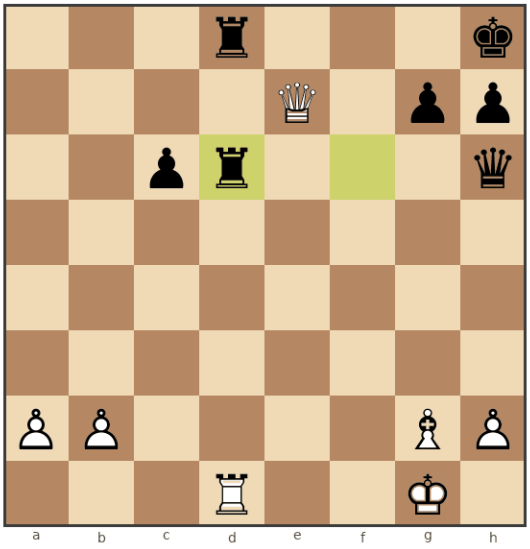
69. White to move · mate in 2



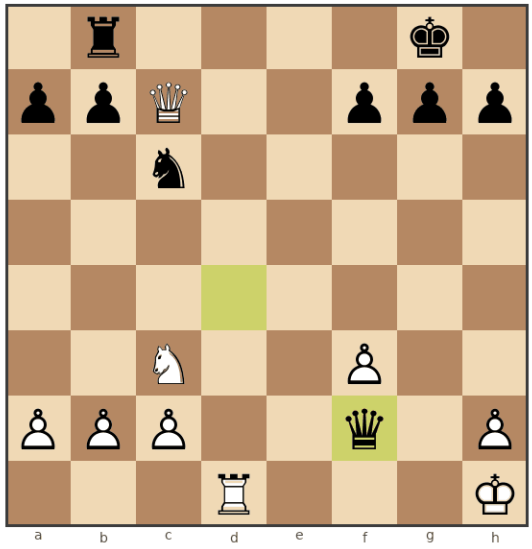
70. White to move · mate in 2



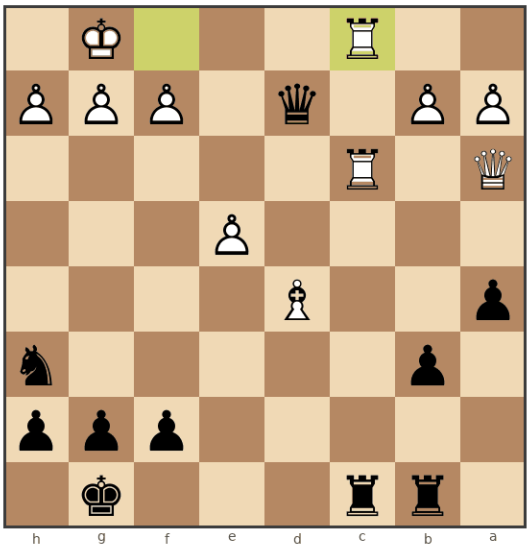
71. White to move · mate in 2



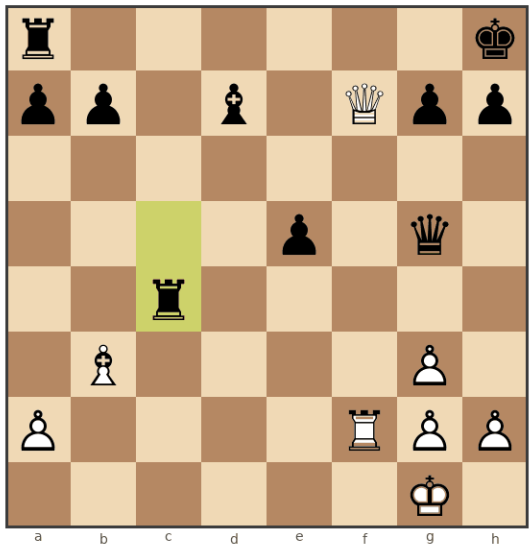
72. White to move · mate in 2



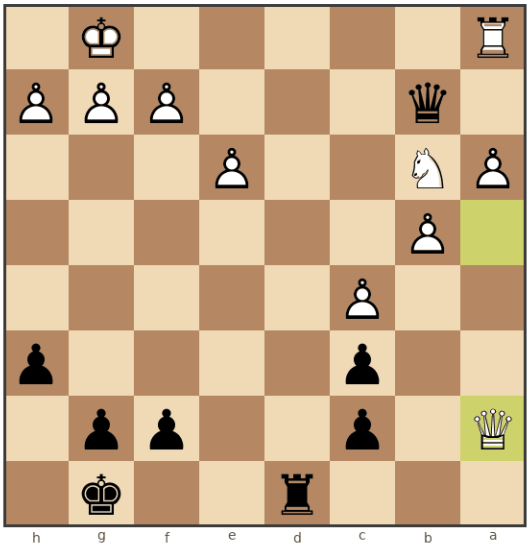
73. Black to move · mate in 2



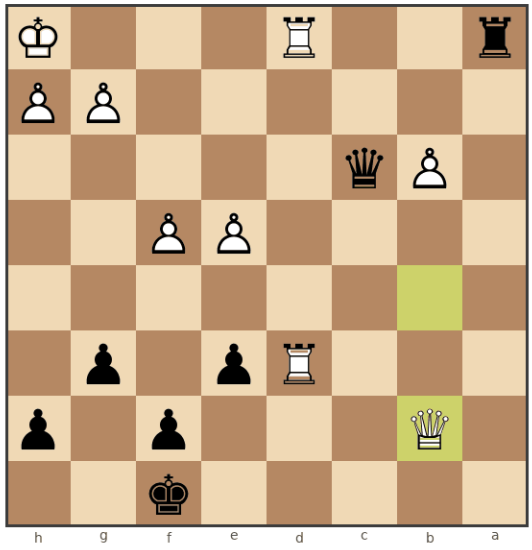
74. White to move · mate in 2



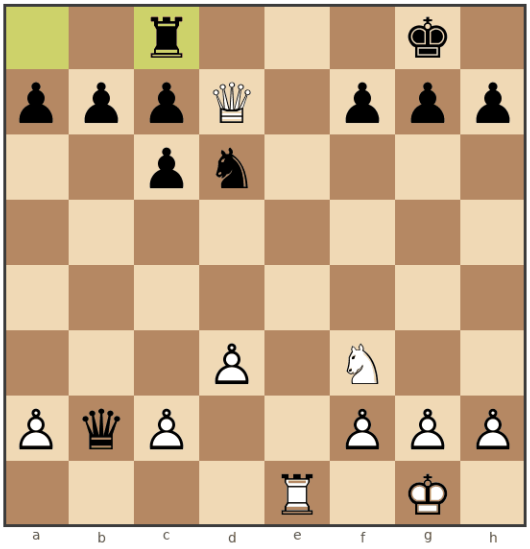
75. Black to move · mate in 2



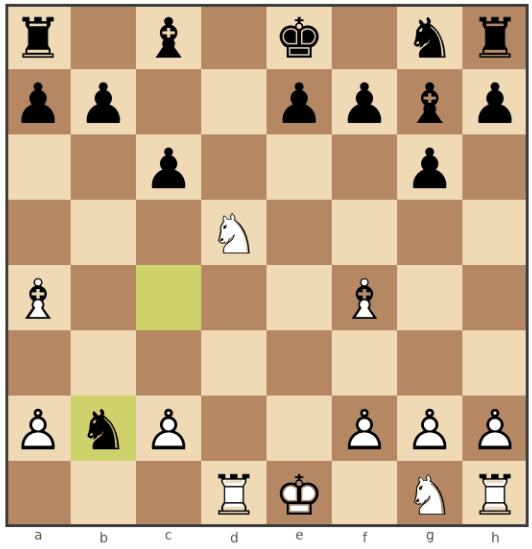
76. Black to move · mate in 2



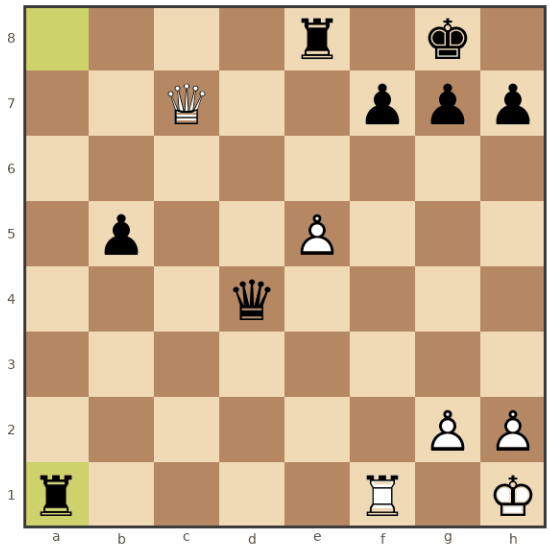
77. White to move · mate in 2



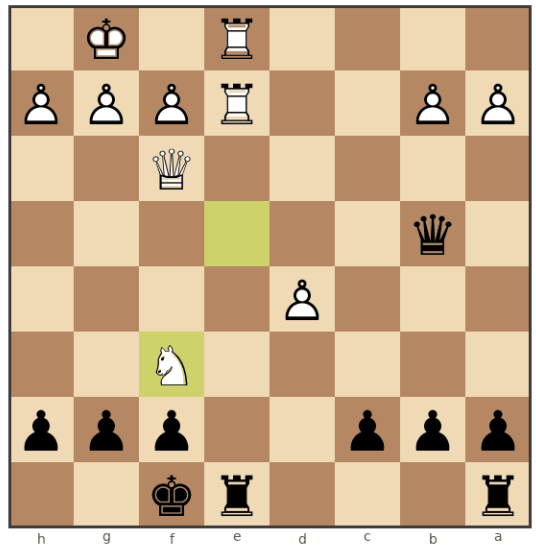
78. White to move · mate in 2



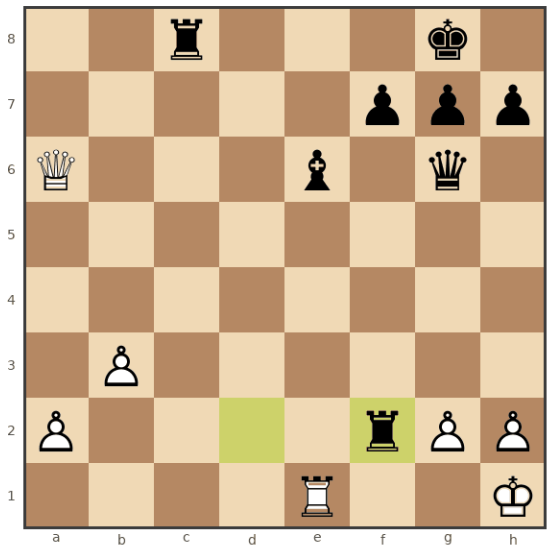
79. White to move · mate in 2



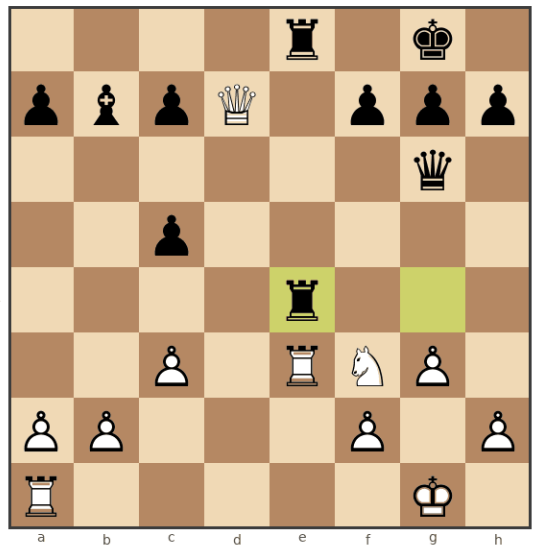
80. Black to move · mate in 2



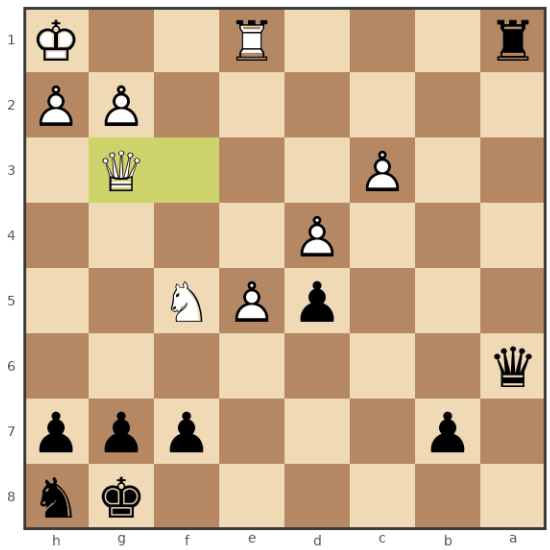
81. White to move · mate in 2



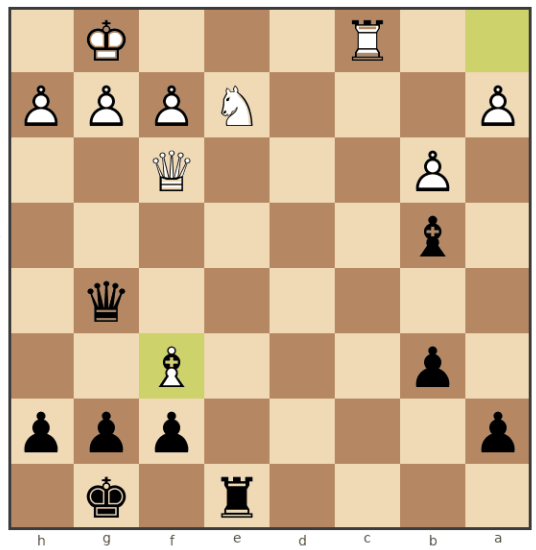
82. White to move · mate in 2



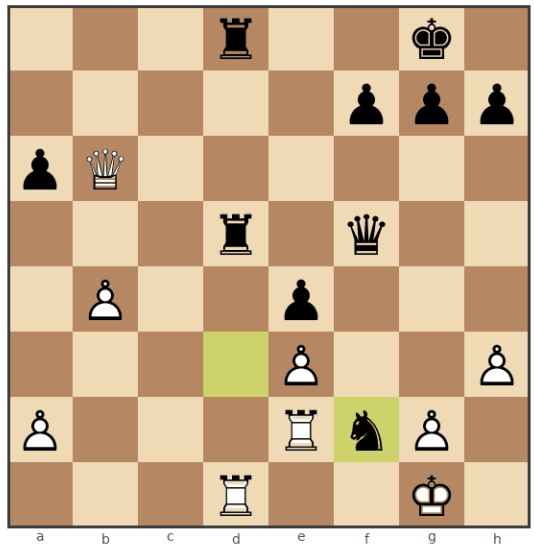
83. Black to move · mate in 2



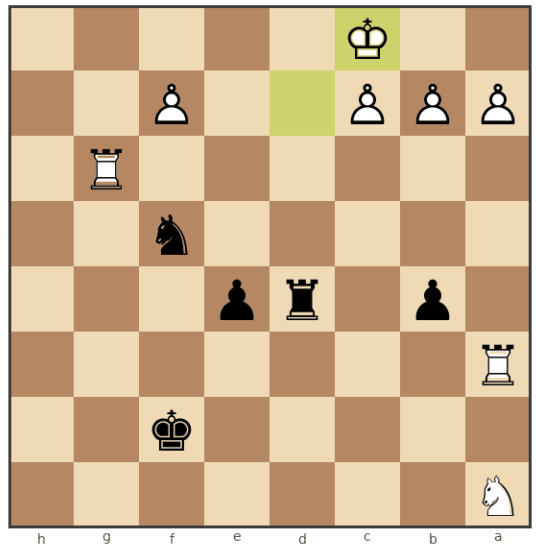
84. Black to move · mate in 2



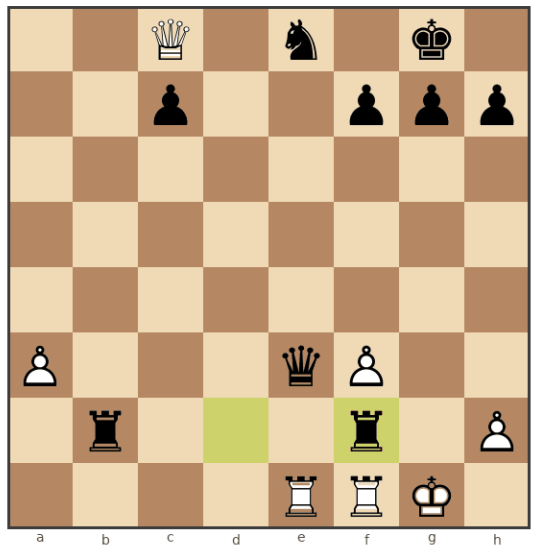
85. White to move · mate in 2



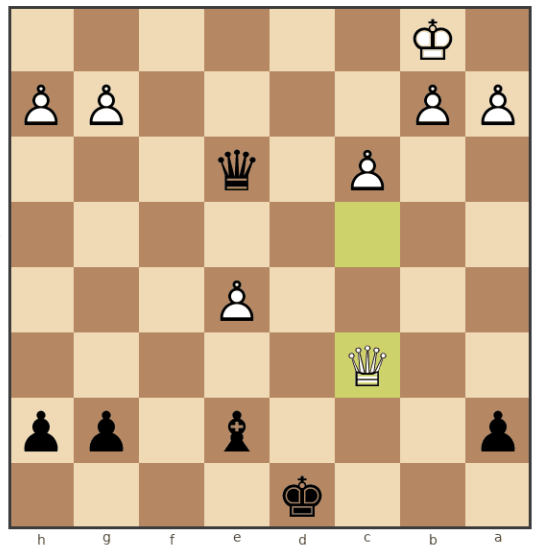
86. Black to move · mate in 2



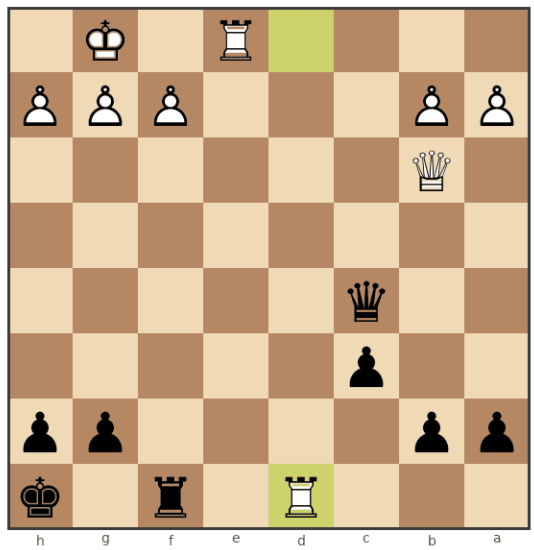
87. White to move · mate in 2



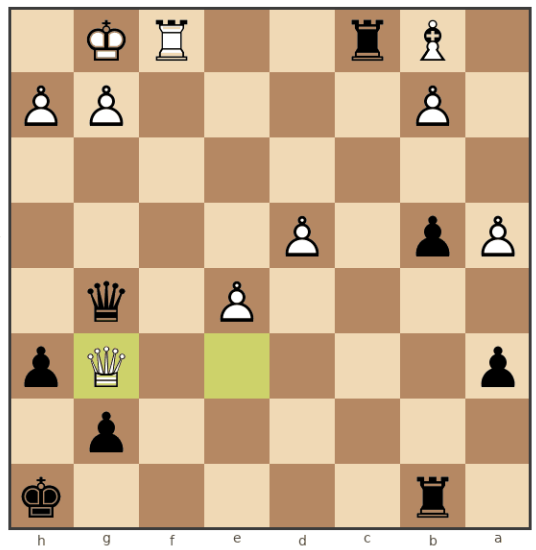
88. Black to move · mate in 2



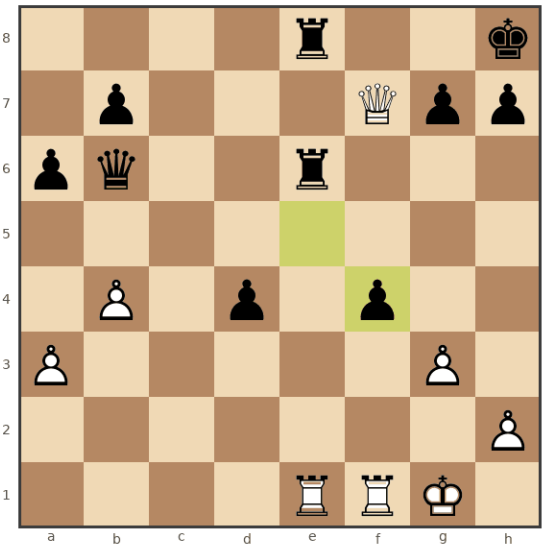
89. Black to move · mate in 2



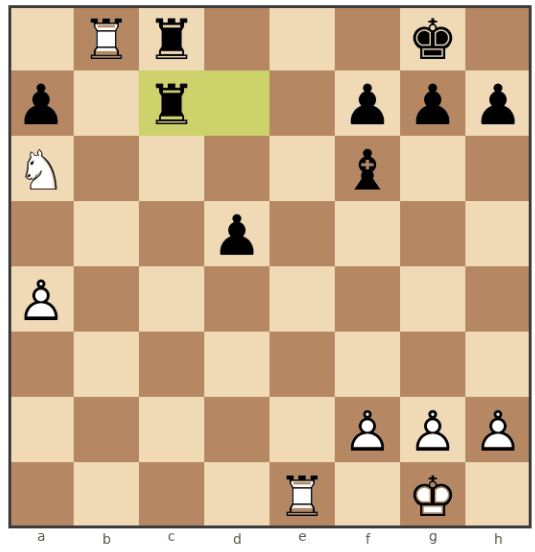
90. Black to move · mate in 2



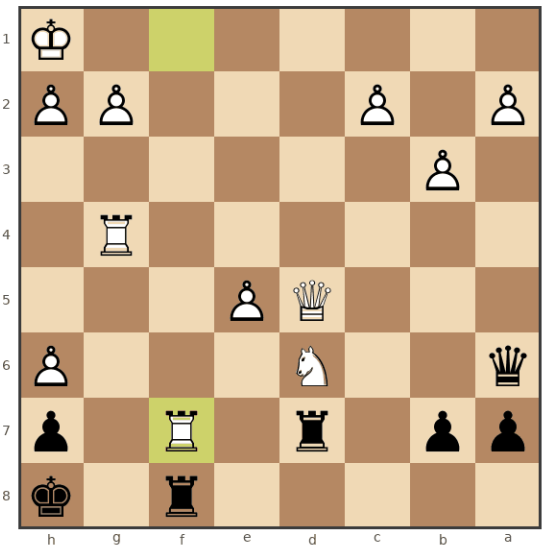
91. White to move · mate in 2



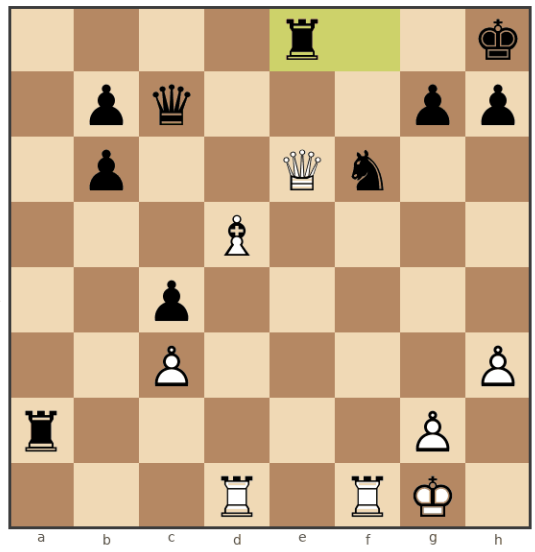
92. White to move · mate in 2



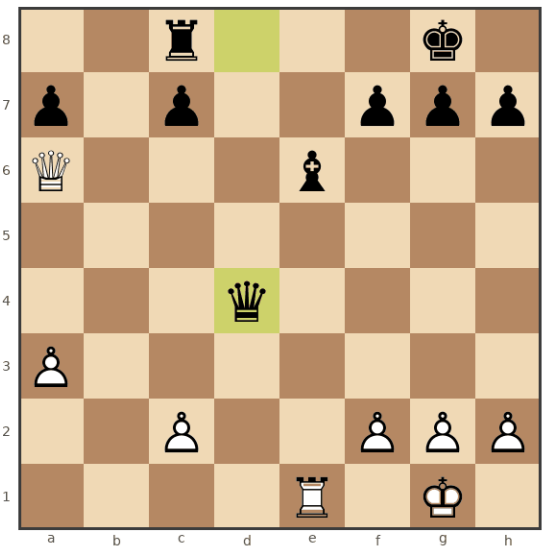
93. Black to move · mate in 2



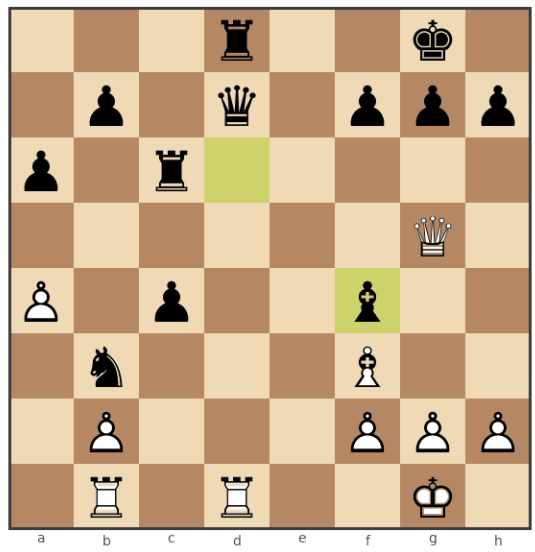
94. White to move · mate in 2



95. White to move · mate in 2



96. White to move · mate in 2



Answers

1. 33... Bxe2+ 34. Qe1 Rxe1# (rating 837, lichess.org/training/6IlCP)
2. 22. Qb8+ Qc8 23. Qxc8# (rating 891, lichess.org/training/9jC5b)
3. 28... Qe1+ 29. Rxe1 Rxe1# (rating 904, lichess.org/training/2mK1K)
4. 34. Rxa8+ Bxa8 35. Rd8# (rating 910, lichess.org/training/8lAeX)
5. 21... Bd3+ 22. Kg1 Re1# (rating 916, lichess.org/training/8hJfH)
6. 32... Be3+ 33. Kh1 Rxf1# (rating 927, lichess.org/training/25dga)
7. 29... Rd1+ 30. Bxd1 Rf1# (rating 941, lichess.org/training/6Pw9Y)
8. 30... Qb1+ 31. Nxb1 Rc1# (rating 947, lichess.org/training/4yif0)
9. 26. Qxc8+ Bxc8 27. Rd8# (rating 958, lichess.org/training/4bUwG)
10. 30... Ne2+ 31. Kb1 Rxd1# (rating 964, lichess.org/training/3FHfV)
11. 22... Qxc1+ 23. Qd1 Qxd1# (rating 971, lichess.org/training/69HrC)
12. 24. Qxf7+ Kh8 25. Qxe8# (rating 974, lichess.org/training/1vduw)
13. 29... Ne2+ 30. Kb1 Rxd1# (rating 980, lichess.org/training/4udHR)
14. 31. Qf7+ Kh8 32. Qxe8# (rating 986, lichess.org/training/144YP)
15. 33. Qd5+ Kh8 34. Rxf8# (rating 988, lichess.org/training/5OIgX)
16. 18. Qxd8+ Bxd8 19. Re8# (rating 993, lichess.org/training/4cAnP)
17. 26... Qd3+ 27. Kg1 Rxe1# (rating 1003, lichess.org/training/8Oqrb)
18. 24... Qxf2+ 25. Kh1 Qxe1# (rating 1024, lichess.org/training/8WRwi)
19. 17. Qe7+ Kg8 18. Qd8# (rating 1037, lichess.org/training/4fYdu)
20. 19. Qxc7+ Ka8 20. Qxd8# (rating 1053, lichess.org/training/9MFy8)
21. 17. Nh6+ Kh8 18. Rxf8# (rating 1057, lichess.org/training/8HnBe)
22. 17... Ne2+ 18. Kh1 Rxf1# (rating 1075, lichess.org/training/13jYn)
23. 23... Ne2+ 24. Kh1 Rxf1# (rating 1096, lichess.org/training/2QWrV)
24. 10. Nxh6+ Kh8 11. Rxf8# (rating 1099, lichess.org/training/7IqSa)
25. 24... Qf1+ 25. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1105, lichess.org/training/2Q5qn)
26. 25... Qf1+ 26. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1108, lichess.org/training/5VXk0)
27. 44... Qxa1+ 45. Bxa1 Re1# (rating 1116, lichess.org/training/0Wwvr)
28. 26. Qxd8+ Rxd8 27. Rxd8# (rating 1118, lichess.org/training/40wkh)
29. 23... Ne2+ 24. Kh1 Rf1# (rating 1122, lichess.org/training/9ZpY3)
30. 28. Qf8+ Rxf8 29. Rxf8# (rating 1127, lichess.org/training/4KU61)
31. 43... Qe3+ 44. Kh1 Qxc1# (rating 1130, lichess.org/training/3R93H)
32. 26... Ne2+ 27. Kh1 Rxf1# (rating 1131, lichess.org/training/6rVG3)
33. 17... Ne2+ 18. Kh1 Rxf1# (rating 1134, lichess.org/training/7Mt0d)
34. 27. Qd6+ Ka8 28. Qxf8# (rating 1137, lichess.org/training/1YvAE)
35. 23. Ne7+ Kh8 24. Rf8# (rating 1140, lichess.org/training/9OS4U)
36. 30. Qd8+ Rxd8 31. Rxd8# (rating 1150, lichess.org/training/2XPzw)
37. 27. Qa8+ Rd8 28. Qxd8# (rating 1155, lichess.org/training/0VbT8)
38. 34. Bc5+ Kg8 35. Qb8# (rating 1158, lichess.org/training/5WuVt)
39. 23. Rd8+ Qe8 24. Rxe8# (rating 1161, lichess.org/training/1C11f)
40. 24... Bd3+ 25. Kg1 Rxe1# (rating 1162, lichess.org/training/61azB)

Answers

41. 35. Rg8+ Rd8 36. Rxd8# (rating 1167, lichess.org/training/6dAlx)
42. 28. Re8+ Rf8 29. Rxf8# (rating 1178, lichess.org/training/1crmG)
43. 28. Qxf7+ Kh8 29. Qxe8# (rating 1180, lichess.org/training/5nRti)
44. 21. Qxd8+ Qxd8 22. Rxd8# (rating 1182, lichess.org/training/5bgyp)
45. 33... Bd4+ 34. Kh1 Rxf1# (rating 1187, lichess.org/training/2eWCF)
46. 32... Qc1+ 33. Rxc1 bxc1=Q# (rating 1189, lichess.org/training/4xR9I)
47. 23... Qxd1+ 24. Rxd1 Rxd1# (rating 1197, lichess.org/training/8hpqx)
48. 18... Rd1+ 19. Re1 Rxe1# (rating 1214, lichess.org/training/9EGp8)
49. 15. Rxf8+ Kxf8 16. Rd8# (rating 1230, lichess.org/training/1oaWv)
50. 15. Nh6+ Kh8 16. Rxf8# (rating 1236, lichess.org/training/87n1h)
51. 19... Qxd1+ 20. Bxd1 Rc1# (rating 1245, lichess.org/training/6EGGQ)
52. 25... Qxd1+ 26. Rxd1 Rxd1# (rating 1252, lichess.org/training/1OKn5)
53. 35. Qf8+ Rxf8 36. Rxf8# (rating 1263, lichess.org/training/3xkAE)
54. 28... Nd2+ 29. Ka1 Rc1# (rating 1270, lichess.org/training/76HHu)
55. 29. Qxe6+ Kh8 30. Qe8# (rating 1276, lichess.org/training/46L5F)
56. 30. Ra8+ Re8 31. Rxe8# (rating 1281, lichess.org/training/8lLu3)
57. 25. Qe8+ Rxe8 26. dxe8=Q# (rating 1286, lichess.org/training/5w8BM)
58. 30... Qxf1+ 31. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1292, lichess.org/training/1nNfP)
59. 30... Qxc1+ 31. Rxc1 Rxc1# (rating 1294, lichess.org/training/4o4X4)
60. 34. Rc8+ Bxc8 35. e8=Q# (rating 1307, lichess.org/training/2abgY)
61. 26... Qf1+ 27. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1309, lichess.org/training/9OMiD)
62. 33. Qd8+ Rxd8 34. Rxd8# (rating 1314, lichess.org/training/9AmWM)
63. 25... Qxc1+ 26. Nxc1 Re1# (rating 1321, lichess.org/training/2kunZ)
64. 28... Qxf1+ 29. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1323, lichess.org/training/1AyBp)
65. 36... Qe1+ 37. Rxe1 dxe1=Q# (rating 1328, lichess.org/training/8MKFN)
66. 26... Qxc1+ 27. Rxc1 Rxc1# (rating 1331, lichess.org/training/3PJcB)
67. 19... Qf1+ 20. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1334, lichess.org/training/7hNp9)
68. 22. Rxg8+ Kxg8 23. Qd8# (rating 1343, lichess.org/training/6BMg3)
69. 21. Qxa8+ Rc8 22. Qxc8# (rating 1351, lichess.org/training/1zhIt)
70. 40. Qd8+ Bxd8 41. Rf8# (rating 1360, lichess.org/training/5vSL8)
71. 32. Qxd8+ Rxd8 33. Rxd8# (rating 1366, lichess.org/training/9EQI2)
72. 19. Qxb8+ Nxb8 20. Rd8# (rating 1369, lichess.org/training/1Thq5)
73. 23... Qxc1+ 24. Rxc1 Rxc1# (rating 1375, lichess.org/training/3ynmt)
74. 27. Qf8+ Rxf8 28. Rxf8# (rating 1379, lichess.org/training/8fp9N)
75. 31... Qxa1+ 32. Nxa1 Rd1# (rating 1385, lichess.org/training/7ejZQ)
76. 28... Qe1+ 29. Rxe1 Rxe1# (rating 1390, lichess.org/training/7omEc)
77. 19. Qxc8+ Nxc8 20. Re8# (rating 1395, lichess.org/training/1IMtz)
78. 11. Nc7+ Kf8 12. Rd8# (rating 1403, lichess.org/training/4tpFZ)
79. 29. Qxf7+ Kh8 30. Qxe8# (rating 1404, lichess.org/training/6Elke)
80. 19... Qxe1+ 20. Rxe1 Rxe1# (rating 1411, lichess.org/training/5bXct)

Answers

81. 33. Qxc8+ Bxc8 34. Re8# (rating 1420, lichess.org/training/9ZCBq)
82. 18. Qxe8+ Rxe8 19. Rxe8# (rating 1429, lichess.org/training/4XBaX)
83. 29... Qf1+ 30. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1440, lichess.org/training/5dhcj)
84. 23... Qxc1+ 24. Nxc1 Re1# (rating 1449, lichess.org/training/7RPL4)
85. 26. Qxd8+ Rxd8 27. Rxd8# (rating 1456, lichess.org/training/4bi4k)
86. 40... Ne2+ 41. Kb1 Rd1# (rating 1469, lichess.org/training/0oMSW)
87. 23. Qxe8+ Qxe8 24. Rxe8# (rating 1484, lichess.org/training/4fiPg)
88. 24... Qd3+ 25. Ka1 Qf1# (rating 1490, lichess.org/training/8SHUQ)
89. 22... Qxf2+ 23. Kh1 Qxe1# (rating 1499, lichess.org/training/5xooR)
90. 29... Qe3+ 30. Kh1 Rxf1# (rating 1542, lichess.org/training/3g3qj)
91. 29. Qxe8+ Rxe8 30. Rxe8# (rating 1570, lichess.org/training/4bQJu)
92. 27. Re8+ Rxe8 28. Rxe8# (rating 1585, lichess.org/training/5Hct1)
93. 27... Qf1+ 28. Rxf1 Rxf1# (rating 1610, lichess.org/training/1vtVm)
94. 26. Qxe8+ Nxe8 27. Rf8# (rating 1622, lichess.org/training/1756r)
95. 20. Qxc8+ Bxc8 21. Re8# (rating 1642, lichess.org/training/8t8Gs)
96. 22. Qxd8+ Qxd8 23. Rxd8# (rating 1649, lichess.org/training/4u9xn)